The 25th Degree – Knight of the Brazen Serpent



The apron is white, lined and edged with black; the white side spotted with golden stars, and the black side with silver ones. Those on the white side represent, by their positions and distances, the Pleiades, the Hyades, Orion and Capella. Those on the black side represent the stars of Perseus, Scorpio and Ursa Major. In the middle of the white side is a triangle in a glory, in the center of which is the name of Deity in Phoenician characters. On the flap is a serpent in a circle, with his tail in his mouth; and in the center of the circle so formed a scarab, or beetle. Over this is a star of gold, with the letter “R” (for Regulus) over it; on the right side of the apron another, with the letter “A” over it; on the left side another, with the letter “A” over it; and at the bottom of the apron another, with the letter “F” over it. These last three letters have the same meaning as on the order explained below.

The order is a crimson ribbon, on which are embroidered the words, one under the other: OSIRIS, AHURA, OSARSIPH, MOSES. Under them a bull, with a disk, surmounted by a crescent between his horns. This is worn from left to right; and across it, from right to left, is worn a broad, white, watered ribbon, on which are the words ISIS and CERES over a dog's head and a crescent. On the right breast, on the left breast, and at the crossing of these orders is a star of gold. Under that on the right breast is the letter "A" (for Aldebaran) ; under that on the left breast the letter "A" (for Antares) ; and under that, at the crossing of the orders, the letter "F" (for Fomalhaut). On the crimson cordon is the word GEBURAH (valor) in Hebrew; and on the white, the Hebrew word AUN (force or strength). Together they mean the generative power and the productive power of nature.

The jewel is a Tau cross, of gold, surmounted by a circle– the Crux Ansata of Egypt– round which a serpent is entwined. On the upright part of the cross is engraved the Hebrew word meaning "he has suffered" or "been wounded," and on the arms the Hebrew word given in the Bible for the brazen serpent, "Nakhushtan."

DUTY

Fulfill your destiny and re–create yourself by reformation, repentance and enlarging your knowledge.

LESSONS

Man is composed of the flesh, the soul and the intellect.
Man is a reflection of the Divine. Do not weary God with petitions.

FOR REFLECTION

Is it possible to find your way to Heaven alone?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Sun, moon, brazen serpent, Pythagorean right triangle.

Islam, or Mohammedanism as Pike calls it, has been one of the major religions in the world for over eleven centuries. In an older form of this degree, some

Islamic doctrine is presented through the re–creation of initiation into the elite group among the Druse, a quasi–Islamic religious sect living in the Lebanon area; we encountered the Druse previously in the 22nd Degree, Prince of Libanus.

The Druse are particularly known for secrecy and silence regarding their religious beliefs. Their vows of secrecy are so effective that very little is factually known of their beliefs. Any search for such an understanding is inhibited by the Druse practice of assuming the beliefs of the religion of their surroundings for the purpose of concealing their own doctrines; however, it is believed the Druse religious system is basically Islamic intermingled with Gnostic, Christian and Hebrew doctrine.

Pike radically changed this degree in his reworking of the old ritual of the Rite. The characters in the old rituals were Hebrew, that is, Moses, Aaron, Joshua and the candidate, a traveler. In Pike's version, the presiding officer is called the Hakam, meaning "wise" or "skilled" in Arabic, and the candidate represents an Ismaeli (a member of one of the major sects of Islam) in the area around Lebanon during the reign of Sayeed Abdullah, Great Emir of the Druses in 1450 A.D. The candidate seeks initiation into the Druse system that he might become an Akal, a disciple of the Order of Truth. By 1450 the Druse and Ismaeli were clearly independent Islamic sects. Although it is believed the Druse do not recognize conversion to their faith, this may not have been known by Pike when he wrote this degree. In any event, history provides the general legend for the degree and Pike provides the details. In both cases, the emphasis is on the religion of Islam.

The Older Pike Ritual:

CEREMONY

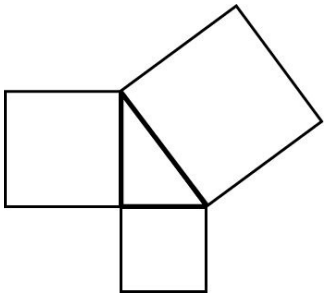
The ceremony took place in four apartments. They are all remarkable in their simplicity. The first is called the House of the Earth. The floor is covered with coarse matting and the walls are gray, a color made by combining black with

white, symbolizing the union of the earthly and the divine. A gray curtain hangs in one corner behind which is a chair. A stool and a small table are the only furnishings. A book, three candles, pen and paper are on the table.

The second apartment is called the House of the Planets. It is the same as the first apartment except that the walls are sky blue, a color symbolic of the heavens and so of Deity. Five candles of different colors– orange, red, blue, green and purple– sit on the table. Transparencies in the East, West and South display, respectively, the signs of Mercury and Venus, Mars and Jupiter, and Saturn, five of the seven planets known to the ancients.

The third apartment is also like the first and is styled the House of the Sun and Moon. A second table is added to the room; an incense censer and four gilded candlesticks are on it. The other table has a book, pen, paper and three green candles. The transparency in the East pictures the rising sun and that in the West shows a setting new moon.

The principal chamber is called the House of the Light. Nine lights (candles) are arranged on the altar in groups of three, forming a representation of the Pythagorean Theorem, first discussed in the 20th Degree:



On the altar are: an incense censer, the Bible, the Hebrew Pentateuch, the Koran (the Holy Book of Islam), and a bound book like those in the other apartments. In the East hangs a circular transparency showing a round disk of white light around which are five stars of various colors: crimson, rose, orange, green and violet. At the Hakam’s right is a column on which is a staff with a bronze serpent twined around the top.

The lodge, called a Synod (from the Greek word for “assembly”), opens in the House of the Light. The unique opening combines silence with gestures which

symbolically summarize important teachings in the degree.

The candidate, dressed in a long gray robe, is taken to the House of the Earth, the first apartment, seated on the stool and left utterly alone in total silence. A full five minutes of silence is broken by the sound of a large bell or gong being struck three times followed by a dirge (somber, sad music) played on the organ. A voice from behind the curtain instructs the candidate to read aloud from a book on the table; in fact, all the verbal instruction in the House of the Earth is given by the candidate reading aloud. He declares that he reads with an earnest, teachable spirit and states, “There is no god but God; and the teachers of the Truth are His Prophets.” This statement is a slightly modified version of the Kalima, the creed of Islam which says, “There is no god but God and Mohammed is his prophet.”

The candidate must take account of his own vices, faults and sins. In writing he is required to promise to rid himself of just one shortcoming, the one which he truly believes can be mastered. If the candidate denies he has any faults, vices or sins, he is dismissed. A man who denies his weaknesses is too “wise in his own conceit” (Proverbs 26:5) and will not benefit from initiation.

Following this symbolic purification, the candidate reads the philosophical instruction in the House of the Earth. The three lights represent the forces of nature– attraction, mobility and vitality. We only know of these forces from the effects of each, which we acquire via our senses. Just as we know the force itself by the manifested energies of the force, so we know the soul by its thoughts and we know God, or the First Cause, by His revelations in the universe and our own souls.

A masked and silent officer then conducts the candidate to the second apartment, the House of the Planets, and seats him upon the stool. After five minutes of silence, a large bell strikes five times and solemn music is played. The candidate again is instructed to read aloud from the book on the table which contains passages from the Koran. He is instructed to be thankful to God, constant in prayer, penitent and humble, forgiving, generous, merciful, and endeavor not to live for thyself alone, but so that when thou hast died there shall

be some to stand up and say, “Dear God, it has been well for us that Thou didst let him live. He has not wished to find his way to heaven alone.”

The candidate must then solemnly vow to govern his life by the virtues he has just read. Derisive laughter and sarcastic remarks from the brethren behind the curtain are aimed at the ease with which the candidate makes this vow to live a life of total perfection. As weeds are best taken up one at a time by the roots, so too it is best to vow the performance of just one duty faithfully and constantly. Again, the candidate is asked to write on the paper one duty which he has neglected to perform or poorly performed and promises to better perform it. If he cannot or will not do so, he is dismissed for initiation cannot make him wiser.

In this, the House of the Planets, the candidate reads that light is an effluence from God, the source of life and light. God is also the intellect and the source of all intelligence. Just as God has given the senses to his creatures, He has given us a ray of the divine light and with His will impresses convictions upon our souls. He has made man to be a reflection of Himself, as the light from the moon and planets are a reflection of the sun.

The candidate is then conducted to the House of the Sun and Moon in silence, which is again maintained for five minutes. A bell is sounded seven times, followed by a hymn. The candidate reads aloud passages, some of which are from the Koran, about the mystery of how God communicates with man and man’s inability to properly conceive of God. We learn that ignorance corrupts into falsehoods the truths of both religion and philosophy. Lessons which are mere allegories are taken for literal truth and the teachings of the sages are lost. The Koran says that God chooses His messengers from among the angels and from among men and so He speaks to us by revelation from behind a veil or by sending His angels to reveal that which He pleases; to the ancient Arabs the sun, the moon and the five planets represented these angels. Despite messages from God, human reason is utterly powerless to form any conception of what He is. So God is personified by words normally used to described the attributes of men: wisdom, will, sovereignty. No qualities should be ascribed to God. His power is revealed to us in nature but we hardly understand nature better than we

understand God. The forces of nature should be understood as His varied actions, but nature is not God. In writing, the candidate must affirm his belief in one supreme Intelligence: a Creator of the universe who reveals Himself therein like the soul reveals itself in thoughts, words and works.

Having passed through the House of the Earth, the House of the Planets and the House of the Sun and Moon, the candidate enters the House of the Light. The officers instruct him on the importance of the night sky to the ancients, particularly the desert tribes of the Middle East. The instruction is calculated to give a deep appreciation for the reverence paid by the ancients to the night sky and its dominant occupants: the sun, moon, planets, constellations, and even individual stars, many of which they assigned benign or malignant influences. The darkened vault of heaven figured as their calendar and their book of mythology. By it they planted or harvested crops and celebrated religious rites; upon it they wrote the epics of their greatest heroes and villains; from it they contracted marriages, named their children, and planned the course of their lives. Though wise men from Job to Augustine railed against astrology, kings have continued to wage war and make peace at the dictates of the heavens and even today we are not freed from its influence.

The events in the sky at the vernal equinox became symbolic of the final victory of light over darkness, truth over falsehood, intelligence over superstition and right over wrong. For this wondrous, ever revolving, ever reminding circle of change men should give thanks to God and not weary Him with petitions. This lesson is allegorically presented in the story from Scripture which gives this degree its name. The children of Israel wandering in the wilderness of Sinai tire of the manna given by God to sustain them and rail against Moses that he and God have brought them out of Egypt to die in the wilderness. For their ingratitude the Lord sends venomous serpents among them and many die. Realizing their sin, the people and Moses pray that the serpents be taken away. At God’s instruction Moses erects a pole with a brazen serpent upon it; any who are bitten may look upon it and not die (Numbers 21). In time this brazen serpent was itself worshiped. This story contains many lessons: to be thankful to God for

what we have; to be vigilant so as not to corrupt or be corrupted; and especially, wise faith coupled with sound reason is a conviction which itself is the word of God in the human soul.

After receiving the white turban, an emblem of purity of faith and a Knight of the Brazen Serpent, the candidate receives instruction in the divine hierarchy of the Druse, represented by the five stars of different colors on the white disk suspended in the East. The disk symbolizes Albar the Most High, or the Deity, who from His glorious light produced the universal Intelligence. From the light of Intelligence He produced the Soul; from the light of the Soul, the Word; from the light of the Word, the Preceding; from the light of the Preceding, the Following; and from the light of the Following, the Universe. The divine Soul is said to be the cause of the production of the universe and within man it is emotion, feeling, sympathy, justice, beneficence, the moral being of God, or simply, all that of the divine nature which is spoken of as the heart of man. The Word is produced from the light of the Soul which itself is produced from the light of the Intellect. The union of Intelligence and the Soul create the Word, which is the utterance of the divine Intellect and Affection united. The Preceding is the supremacy of God and from His sovereignty comes all that ever was or will be. The Following is the Preceding in action and from the light of the Following, the Lord produced the Universe and all that it contains. Concealed within this explanation are great truths. Like these ideas which in a cyclical, or circular, fashion create one and then the other, so too, the destiny of man is to make or create himself.

In the House of the Earth, the earthly dimension was emphasized, that is, our duty to our fellow men and God and the weakness and frailty of the flesh. In the House of the Planets, the soul is the principle concern; we learn the soul of man is a part of the Divine. In the House of the Sun and Moon we learn that within man is the divine Intelligence. The threefold nature of man—his flesh, his soul and his intellect—combine to form the human. When cultivated properly, the voice of God may be heard in the human mind and heart.

The final instruction is an admonition not to be content with what we have already learned, for to cease study would only cause us to lose what we have already gained. We should all remember that:

> *The brightest and sharpest sword, left to remain long in the scabbard rusts and loses its edge; and the intellect, left to lie fallow, becomes arid and barren.*

The Revised Standard Pike Ritual:

Although creative and instructive, Pike's version of this degree did not consider that the Sufi, rather than the Druse, represented the mystical tradition of Islam. The revised ritual corrected this deficiency and introduced modifications which more accurately presented this tradition while retaining many of the tradition Masonic elements, as well as artifacts of the Pike ritual.

Bodies of this Degree are styled a "Synod" (from the Greek, meaning: "a coming together, assembly, meeting"). The Lodge represents a tent in the desert is styled "The House of the Light," *baith h'aur.* The term "Sufi" derives from the Arabic word for "wool," a reference to the garments worn by these Islamic mystics.

A transparency in the east displays the rising sun and one in the west, the setting new moon, each on a sky-blue background. On the right of the Presiding Officer is a short column, square, on which stands a staff, having a serpent twined round the upper end.

The Presiding Officer is styled First Sufi Master. The Wardens are respectively styled Second and Third Sufi Master. The Orator is styled Fourth Sufi Master. The Master of Ceremonies is styled Abdullah. All the Brethren are clothed in long white robes, with full sleeves, rope belts, and wear turbans of white muslin. They wear no cordon or apron. The jewel is a tau cross, surmounted by a circle, all of gold, round which, at, below and above the junction is entwined a serpent, enameled of steel, blue color. On the upright part of the cross is engraved the Hebrew word *khalatai*, "he has been wounded," and on the arms the Hebrew word *nakhushtan*, "the serpent of brass."

CEREMONY

The candidate, representing Idris, an initiate of the mysteries, is introduced to the Sufi Masters by Abdullah, who vouches for his fidelity. The Sufi Masters question whether the candidate has his performed his obligations and duties. They observe that many men assume vows but afterwards neglect them. After the candidate is questioned on the tenets of Islam he informs them that he desires to receive greater knowledge and learn truth.

The Masters inform Idris that truth is elusive and, though present, is often not recognized. Reciting some of the allegorical teachings of Mullah Nasruddin, they instruct the candidate in a new way of viewing things. Although their instruction seems light–hearted, it causes the candidate to reconsider preconceptions and prejudices, as well to teach him that logic and reason are within the grasp of anyone who is willing to open his mind. He learns that even humorous anecdotes may contain profound lessons.

The relationship between light and truth is discussed, and a verse in the *Quran*, which declares that "Allah [God] is the light of the heavens and the earth," is discussed. God is light. He speaks to the heart and inspires believers to do His will.

LECTURE

The introductory paragraph in *Morals and Dogma* summarizes the purpose of this lecture:

This Degree is both philosophical and moral. While it teaches the necessity of reformation as well as repentance, as a means of obtaining mercy and forgiveness, it is also devoted to an explanation of the symbols of Masonry; and especially to those which are connected with the ancient and universal legend, of which that of Khir–Om Abi [Hiram Abif] *is but a variation; that legend which, representing a murder or a death, and a restoration to life, by a drama in which figure Osiris, Isis and Horus, ... and many another representative of the active and passive Powers of Nature, taught the Initiates in the Mysteries that the rule*

of Evil and Darkness is but temporary, and that that of Light and Good will be eternal (p. 435).

To elaborate the teachings of this degree, four general topics are discussed in great detail: the soul, the heavens, the serpent and symbolism. The discussions are not limited to the Islamic perspective but include a vast range of cultures for the purpose of showing a common thread among the religious and philosophical ideas of the ancients.

The soul and the heavens were closely linked in the minds of the ancients because they believed the soul originated in the heavens, descending upon birth and ascending upon death through the stars. The serpent in the night sky is called the constellation Scorpio and was thought by them to be along the path followed by souls in their descent to earth. So, the serpent became a symbol of malevolence; in the night sky Scorpio ushers in the period of darkness at the autumnal equinox. The serpent was also a symbol of eternity and immortality because in shedding its skin, it was thought to renew its youth.

Since the purpose of the initiations was to purify the soul and impart to man hope for a future life and because the heavens were looked upon with awe by the ancients, the paths of the stars and planets were imparted with a great deal of symbolic meaning. In time the wonder about the heavens became, among the profane, a worship of the heavens. Their corruption of the symbol for the thing symbolized should not be viewed with disdain. Understanding human nature, we should look upon the confounding of symbols with charity, studying their ancient knowledge in order to formulate our own convictions about the soul, the Deity, and truth. The wonderings of the ancients, particularly the Babylonian Magi, about the night sky were indeed the first religion and the first philosophy. Their exacting calculations and observations established the saros, the cycle of solar eclipses, and removed from the hearts of the populace the most unimaginable terrors. That such knowledge became corrupted and occasionally even became an instrument of political and religious repression only serves to

demonstrate how little man has changed over the centuries, first gaining a pure knowledge and then corrupting its use for base ends.

The Soul:

As you learned in the 24th Degree, my Brother, the ancient Philosophers regarded the soul of man as having had its origin in Heaven. ...the Mysteries taught the great doctrine of the divine nature and longings after immortality of the soul, of the nobility of its origin, the grandeur of its destiny, its superiority over the animals who have no aspirations heavenward (p. 436).

Let us, in order to understand this old Thought, first follow the soul in its descent. The sphere or Heaven of the fixed stars was that Holy Region, ...But those who from that lofty abode, where they were lapped in eternal light, have looked longingly toward the body, and toward that which we here below call life, but which is to the soul a real death; and who have conceived for it a secret desire ... are attracted by degrees toward the inferior regions of the world, by the mere weight of thought and of that terrestrial desire (p. 437).

On its [the soul's] *return, it restores to each sphere through which it ascends, the passions and earthly faculties received from them: to the Moon, the faculty of increase and diminution of the body; to Mercury, fraud, the architect of evils; to Venus, the seductive love of pleasure; to the Sun, the passion for greatness and empire; to Mars, audacity and temerity; to Jupiter, avarice; and to Saturn, falsehood and deceit; and at last, relieved of care, it enters naked and pure into the eighth sphere or highest Heaven* (pp. 439–440).

We smile at these notions of the ancients; but we must learn to look through these material images and allegories, to the ideas, struggling for utterance, the great speechless thoughts which they envelop: and it is well for us to consider whether we ourselves have yet found out any better way of representing to ourselves the soul's origin and its advent into this body, so entirely foreign to it; if, indeed, we have ever thought about it at all; or have not ceased to think, in despair (p. 438).

Like the belief in a Deity, the belief in the soul's immortality is rather a natural feeling, an adjunct of self–consciousness, than a dogma belonging to any particular age or country. It gives eternity to man's nature, and reconciles its seeming anomalies and contradictions; it makes him strong in weakness and perfectible in imperfection; and it alone gives an adequate object for his hopes and energies, and value and dignity to his pursuits (p. 517).

The Heavens:

It is not possible for us thoroughly to appreciate the feelings with which the ancients regarded the Heavenly bodies We wonder and are amazed at the Power and Wisdom (to most men it seems only a kind of Infinite Ingenuity) of the MAKER; they wondered at the Work, and endowed it with Life and Force and mysterious Powers and mighty Influence (pp. 441-442).

The sky was to them a great, solid, concave arch; a hemisphere of unknown material, at an unknown distance above the flat level of earth; and along it journeyed in their courses the Sun, the Moon, the Planets and the Stars (p. 443).

...naturally and necessarily, time was divided, first into days, and then into moons or months, and years; and with these divisions and the movements of the Heavenly bodies that marked them, were associated and connected all men's physical enjoyments and privations. ... And the attentive observer soon noticed that the smaller lights of Heaven were, apparently, even more regular than the Sun and Moon, and foretold with unerring certainty, by their risings and settings, the periods of recurrence of the different phenomena and seasons on which the physical well-being of all men depended. ...and they commenced by giving to particular Stars or groups of Stars the names of those terrestrial objects which seemed connected with them; ... those stars under which the Nile commenced to overflow, Stars of Inundation, or that poured out water (AQUARIUS).

Those Stars among which the Sun was, when he had reached the Northern Tropic and began to retreat Southward, were termed, from his retrograde motion,

the Crab (CANCER).

As the [sun] *approached, in Autumn, the middle point between the Northern and Southern extremes of his journeying, the days and nights became equal; and the stars among which he was then found were called Stars of the Balance (LIBRA).*

Those stars among which the Sun was, when the Lion, driven from the Desert by thirst, came to slake it at the Nile, were called Stars of the Lion (LEO).

Those among which the Sun was at harvest, were called those of the Gleaning Virgin, holding a Sheaf of Wheat (VIRGO).

Those among which he was found in February, when the Ewes brought forth their young, were called Stars of the Lamb (ARIES).

Those in March when it was time to plough, were called Stars of the Ox (TAURUS).

Those under which hot and burning winds came from the desert, venomous like poisonous reptiles, were called Stars of the Scorpion (SCORPIO).

Observing that the annual return of the rising of the Nile was always accompanied by the appearance of a beautiful Star, ... [which] *seemed to warn the husbandman to be careful not to be surprised by the inundation, the Ethiopian compared this act of that Star to that of the Animal which by barking gives warning of danger, and styled it the Dog (SIRIUS)* (pp. 445–446).

Thus, if not the whole truth, it is yet a large part of it, that the Heathen Pantheon, in its infinite diversity of names and personifications, was but a multitudinous, though in its origin unconscious allegory, of which physical phenomena, and principally the Heavenly Bodies, were the fundamental types (p. 508).

The Serpent:

Among the Egyptians, it was a symbol of Divine Wisdom, when extended at length; and, with its tail in its mouth, of Eternity. In the ritual of Zoroaster, the

Serpent was a symbol of the Universe. In China, the ring between two Serpents was the symbol of the world governed by the power and wisdom of the Creator (p. 496).

The eclipses of the sun and moon were believed by the orientals to be caused by the assaults of a demon in dragon–form; and they endeavored to scare away the intruder by shouts and menaces (p. 498).

... these Asiatic symbols of the contest of the Sun–God with the Dragon of darkness and Winter were imported not only into the Zodiac, but into the more homely circle of European legend; and both Thor and Odin fight with dragons, as Apollo did with Python, the great scaly snake, ... In the Apocryphal book of Esther, dragons herald "a day of darkness and obscurity"; ... (p. 499).

Symbolism:

All religious expression is symbolism; since we can describe only what we see; and the true objects of religion are unseen. The earliest instruments of education were symbols; and they and all other religious forms differed and still differ according to external circumstances and imagery, and according to differences of knowledge and mental cultivation. To present a visible symbol to the eye of another is not to inform him of the meaning which that symbol has to you (pp. 512–513).

No symbol of Deity can be appropriate or durable except in a relative or moral sense. We cannot exalt words that have only a sensuous meaning, above sense. To call Him a Power or a Force, or an Intelligence, is merely to deceive ourselves into the belief that we use words that have a meaning to us, when they have none, or at least no more than the ancient visible symbols had (p. 513).

Men cannot worship a mere abstraction. They require some outward form in which to clothe their conceptions, and invest their sympathies. If they do not shape and carve or paint visible images, they have invisible ones, perhaps quite as inadequate and unfaithful, within their own mind (p. 514).

Let not our objects as Masons fall below theirs [the ancients]. *We use the symbols which they used; and teach the same great cardinal doctrines that they taught, of the existence of an intellectual God, and the immortality of the soul of man. If the details of their doctrines as to the soul seem to us to verge on absurdity, let us compare them with the common notions of our own day, and be silent* (p. 522).

And let us ever remember the words of an old writer, with which we conclude this lecture: "... Certainly it is Heaven upon Earth to have a man's mind move in charity, rest in Providence, AND TURN UPON THE POLES OF TRUTH" (p. 523).